

THE NEW ERA

Liberalization and the new millennium brought with it a multitude of challenges for the railways. From trying to remain relevant in an age of affordable airfare and quick travel to providing efficient freight services and staying environmentally conscious, the Indian Railways has its share of work cut out.

Liberalization in the early 1990s changed the face of the Indian economy and the railways, which operated under the direction of the Indian Government. By the time the millennium came around, the Indian Railways had a new set of challenges, from modernization and changing technologies, to competition from airlines offering cheap fares and discerning travellers seeking speedy, comfortable, and competitively priced travel. Equally important was the need to make freight services profitable once again.

Top on the railways' list was the need to adapt and stay relevant while transforming itself, as authors V Nilakant and S Ramnarayan wrote in their book *Changing Tracks: Reinventing the Spirit of India*: " ... from a colonial workhorse and social equalizer into a modern piece of critical infrastructure carrying India into the 21st century ... ". It is no wonder that the Indian Railways' Vision 2020 statement was to "reinvent" the system so that it was "fast, punctual, comfortable, clean, and indeed, memorable". Alongside key infrastructural changes, there were legislative decisions as well that have impacted the system.

Changing legislation

An interesting, yet significant, change took place in 2012 in the British Parliament with the phasing out of 38 Acts that were put in place during the British rule. They were considered "as being spent, obsolete, unnecessary or otherwise not now of practical utility".

More recently, in 2017, the Indian Government ended the 92-year-old practice of maintaining two separate Budgets – Railways and General.